



helped the side set up a Round of 16 clash with France.

It was remarkable that the side was shown no yellow cards in comparison to France's three despite incessant fouling and provocative behaviour. But Didier Deschamps' side managed a 1-0 win to end Paraguay's wild ride at the tournament. "France couldn't find the answers, and it took a bit of individual skill and a penalty given by VAR to make the difference which their football had not been able to do," a proud Alfaro said, insisting his side "fought like lions".

Despite the numerous fairytales that emerged throughout the course of the tournament, no team was more deserving of the 'dark horse' tag than Norway. The Nordic nation had been a stranger to the "greatest show on Earth" for 28 years. In fact, more than half the squad were not

even born when Norway last featured at the World Cup.

But talent was aplenty. With the likes of Erling Haaland, Martin Odegaard and Alexander Sorloth in its ranks and a nothing-to-lose attitude, the Vikings swiftly became a fan favourite.

Haaland was at the forefront as the Norwegians swept aside Iraq and Senegal before unapologetically resting 10 of their players in the loss against France to round off the group stage.

Each of Norway's victories was punctuated by its now-iconic rowing celebration, a gesture that quickly became a global craze. The fairytale gathered pace in the knockout stage, where a Haaland brace inspired a stunning Round of 16 upset over five-time champion Brazil.

But even the most exciting tales run out of pages, and Norway met its

Nordic force: Few players have occupied football's imagination quite like Erling Haaland. Already one of the game's defining figures, he became the face of Norway's long-awaited return to the World Cup's grand stage. AP

match against England, specifically Jude Bellingham, in the quarterfinals. A historic maiden quarterfinal appearance will only be a first step for a side that is certain to be at the forefront of upcoming major competitions.

The expanded tournament may have been met with a lot of criticism, with the preference for the status quo outweighing the desire for a fresh narrative. But without this opportunity, some of these storylines might have remained unwritten in the journal of the global football carnival.